

Data Limitations Reflection

The data collected through this pipeline has several limitations worth noting.

Selection bias. Applicants who choose to post on GradCafe are self-selected, not a random sample of all graduate applicants. Posting is more common among applicants who received a decision they wanted to share, meaning acceptances may be overrepresented relative to rejections in the raw pool of submissions.

Missingness. Not every applicant fills in every field. GPA, GRE, GRE Verbal, and GRE Analytical Writing scores are only present when the original poster chose to include them, so any average computed from these fields reflects only the subset of applicants who reported that value, not the full population of applicants.

Representativeness. GradCafe's user base skews toward certain fields, such as competitive STEM and PhD programs, and toward applicants who are actively following admissions cycles online. Results may not generalize well to less GradCafe-active groups, such as applicants to smaller or less research-focused programs.

Reliability. All data is self-reported by applicants and is not independently verified against university records, so individual entries could contain errors, exaggerations, or outdated information. For example, an applicant later withdrawing an application would not be reflected in the original post. The GRE field in this dataset also mixes two different scoring scales — the pre-2011 combined score (260-340) and the current single-section score (130-170) — which cannot be meaningfully averaged together; the reported GRE average of 256.39 should be read with this caveat rather than as a directly interpretable number.

Looking at my own computed values: out of 19,707 Fall 2026 applications in the dataset, 38.65% were marked as accepted — likely higher than the true acceptance rate across all applicants to these programs, given the selection bias described above (applicants who get in are more likely to post). The average GPA across all applicants with a reported score was 3.77, and interestingly, the average GPA among accepted students was also 3.77 — nearly identical to rejected (3.78) and waitlisted (3.79) applicants. This suggests that, at least within the range of GPAs typically posted on GradCafe, GPA alone is a weak predictor of outcome — most GradCafe posters already have GPAs clustered in a fairly narrow, high range, so other factors (fit, research experience, letters, program-specific competitiveness) are likely doing more of the work in admissions decisions than GPA differences within this pool.